

society & the arts BOOKS

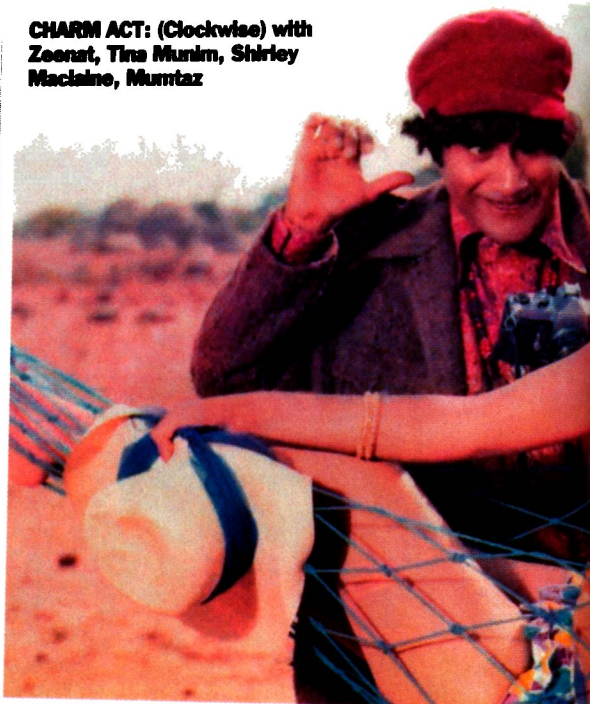
tank. I rushed forward to meet her. She stood up, holding out her arms towards me. We held each other in a long, hot embrace. She did not utter a word, nor did I. After a long silence that said everything, we looked at each other. As I stroked her hair, she held her lips up to me, ready for a kiss. 'Will you marry me?' I asked. She hugged me again and nodded, mumbling, 'I love you! I love you! I love you!'

I went to Zaveri Bazaar and bought one of the costliest rings that would adorn her finger. Divecha took my ring to her house. I was in seventh heaven. We were now engaged! I longed for her, more and more; but I did not hear from her. There was a severe rift in Suraiya's family, nobody taking her side on the issue of her personal emotional involvement except her mother. If she chose to go against the wishes of the family, either she would be eliminated, or the granny would kill herself. Apparently, Suraiya had wept and wept and finally yielded to the pressure mounting on her. She took a solemn oath to throw me completely out of her mind. Later, as an act of desperate frustration, she took the ring I sent her to the seaside, and looking at it for the last time, with all the love she had in her heart for me, threw it far into the sea.

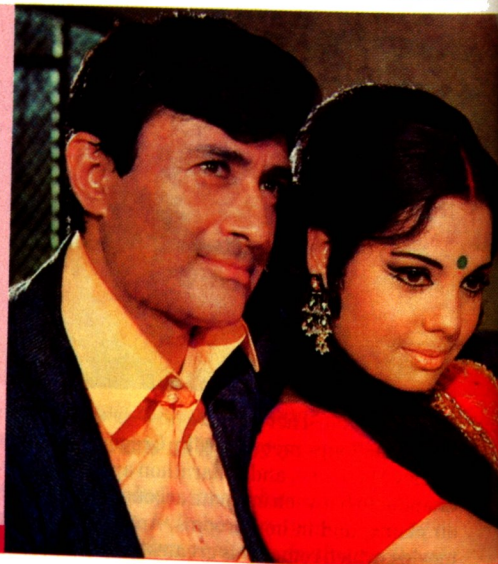
Mona was superb in *Taxi Driver*, enjoying her role to the hilt. She was already a part of Navketan, sailing along with it. In fact, she was Navketan's and Navketan's only. She had started getting outside offers; I felt good for her, but she told me, 'I shall take the best as and when it comes to me!' and hugged me. I understood what she meant. 'But where is the hurry?' I asked her. 'You don't want me to be lost to you!' she put it across smilingly. 'Make a commitment—and I am yours, not only for now, but for all times,' she said. I raised her head and kissed her. She yielded herself to me, and cried. 'Mona!' I mumbled. She stopped crying and looked at me. The innocence in her face was absolute, and so winning! I loved her the most then, more than I loved myself. 'I have decided,' I said. We walked across to the Registrar of Marriages. I took out the ring, put it around her finger. She hugged me shyly. Then we both signed the register and were husband and wife.

I was doing a film with Mumtaz for my brother Goldie called *Tere Mere Sapne*; together we made a good-looking pair. She was friendly, very amiable, an easy-going, uninhibited co-star. We responded to each other exceptionally well on the sets. As soon as she heard of my project to be shot in Nepal, she showed her keenness to participate in it. I gave her a brief narration of the story. 'It's a hell of a role for any girl who does it,' she said, 'but I don't think I want to play your sister.' She was quite emphatic. 'Why not?' I asked her. 'For I don't feel like one, when you are with me,' she explained. We both laughed. 'Would you agree to do the smaller and less significant part?' I asked. 'Only if it is the romantic one,' she replied. 'In that case, let

CHARM ACT: (Clockwise) with Zeenat, Tina Munim, Shirley MacLaine, Mumtaz



MUMTAZ WAS AN UNINHIBITED CO-STAR. 'I DON'T WANT TO PLAY YOUR SISTER,' SHE SAID, 'FOR I DON'T FEEL LIKE ONE WHEN YOU ARE WITH ME.' WE BOTH LAUGHED.



me have the privilege of asking you, "Will you be the romantic leading lady opposite me, Mumsy, in my film *Hare Rama Hare Krishna*?"' I said in great style. She was equally stylish as she answered, 'Privilege granted!' We shook hands.

Zeenat came very appropriately dressed for the party, looking chic and mod and casual, just the image I had of my Janice in *Hare Rama Hare Krishna*. As she sat in front of me, she was a picture of self-confidence, radiating a devil-may-care attitude. 'Are you interested in